

— DRAFT — A PARTNER WORKSTREAM — HACKNEY FOOD HUB GROUP

Buying, storing and feeding Hackney, together.

AN OVERVIEW FOR EVERYONE WORKING ON HACKNEY'S FOOD HUB

A group of Hackney council officers, community food organisations and independent traders has been meeting to work out how the borough's food groups could buy, store and share food collectively, backed by shared infrastructure rather than each organisation funding for itself. This page is a single place to see what that's for, how it connects to work already happening across London, and how it stays coordinated as it develops.

[READ THE AMBITION ↓](#)[SEE WHERE THINGS STAND, IN DETAIL ↗](#)

STATUS — DRAFT, shared for early review · CONVENED BY — Hackney's food hub working group, with Dark Matter Labs facilitating · PART OF — the London Hubs & Markets Working Group

Drawn from Hackney's food hub working sessions and cross-checked against the London Hubs & Markets Working Group's own findings from Lambeth, Newham, Tower Hamlets and Camden + Islington.

— WHY THIS EXISTS

Four things this has to do at once

This isn't only about finding a warehouse. It's about building something that does all four of these together — the same test the wider Food as Infrastructure portfolio holds every idea to.

01 — BUYING POWER

Collective, not each group alone

Hackney's food organisations currently buy separately, mostly at standard retail prices. Buying together — even at small scale — makes better food genuinely affordable, not just a values choice.

02 — A REAL CO-OP, NOT JUST A STORE

Owned and run by the groups that use it

The ambition is a collective food co-op: shared storage and buying power that Hackney's community organisations own and direct, not a service delivered to them from outside.

03 — RESILIENCE

Less exposed to the next shock

Shared storage and shared supplier relationships mean no single organisation's food access depends on one contract, one van, or one good year.

04 — BUILT TO LAST, NOT JUST TO COPE

Community capacity, not just emergency response

The point isn't only to move surplus food more efficiently. It's to build lasting organising and logistics capacity — a foundation to grow from over years, not a one-off pandemic-style response.

— WHO'S IN THE ROOM

A small group, deliberately open to grow

Nobody is claiming to have this solved. The value of the group so far has been in comparing notes honestly — including admitting where it's stuck.

Officers working on poverty reduction, food and economic development

Based in strategy, equalities and community partnerships, with a background in poverty reduction. A new administration has signalled a fresh food strategy, giving this work more explicit mandate — looked at alongside the borough's wider economic development strategy, including how it could support small, independent local food shops, not only community groups.

Food co-ops, an independent grocer, and community food organisations

Includes an established local food cooperative, an independent grocer already trusted by community organisations across Hackney and neighbouring Haringey, and a local food bank whose interest goes beyond food itself — toward helping organisations offer people a way out of poverty, not just a handout.

TWO COORDINATING BODIES

The Hackney Food Network and the relaunching Hackney Food Partnership

The Food Network is the grassroots, community-facing coordination body, running since the pandemic. The Food Partnership is a separate, more policy-focused body — dormant for several years — now relaunching to bring together organisations working on different parts of the food system.

COORDINATING THE HUB NETWORK

Felix Project convenes; Sustain is building the funding case

Felix Project has been working with at least ten boroughs already building or exploring a hub, coordinating the Hubs & Markets Working Group to share best practice and encourage collaboration instead of separate funding bids. That's led to Sustain building a consortium and sharing their National Lottery bid with boroughs, asking for expressions of interest.

THE WIDER PORTFOLIO

Dark Matter Labs: the broader picture of London's buying power

Focused beyond hubs and civic infrastructure alone — on the collective buying power of London as a whole, including larger procurement and business purchases — and building a wider portfolio of work around that focus.

How this connects to the wider work

Hackney is the newest borough working through this — but four others have already built, or are building, a version of the same thing. This effort sits inside a much larger, already-moving picture.

The London Hubs & Markets Working Group

WORKING GROUP

The wider group Hackney is now part of — spanning most of north and east London, comparing real hubs in Lambeth, Newham, Tower Hamlets and Camden + Islington.

OPEN THE WORKING GROUP ↗

Where Hackney stands, in detail

STATE OF PLAY

The fuller working note: what's already been found, mapped directly onto what other boroughs learned, and the concrete next steps.

READ THE DETAIL ↗

Six Pathways to a Civic Food System

WHY THIS MATTERS

The wider argument this work sits inside — six different levers for moving London's buying power behind organic, resilient, civic-led food.

EXPLORE THE PATHWAYS ↗

Food as Infrastructure

THE FULL PORTFOLIO

The full, London-wide portfolio this workstream is one part of — councils, national government and people on the ground building on the same foundations.

OPEN THE PORTFOLIO ↗

— HOW THIS STAYS JOINED UP

Coordination, not just conversation

The group has needed a greater level of coordination at times. These are the mechanisms meant to build that.

NOW

A structuring session, held 22 September

A working session set specifically to bring clarity: rather than wait for a lead to be confirmed, the group agreed one concrete first move everyone could act on immediately — see below.

THE AGREED FIRST MOVE

A phone round, not another survey

Calling round every Hackney community food organisation directly to find out real monthly food spend — a written survey tried this earlier and got almost no responses. Building the relationship and collecting the number at the same time.

STANDING

The London Hubs & Markets Working Group, bi-monthly

Hackney now sits inside a wider, regularly-meeting group comparing real hub examples across boroughs — so lessons travel both ways, not just from Hackney out.

↳ [SEE THE WORKING GROUP'S OWN WORK-AHEAD LIST](#)

SHARED RESOURCE

The Hub Documentation library

A shared library of hub proposals, capacity models and go-live plans from every borough already building one — the first place to look before designing something from scratch.

PRACTICAL HABIT

One shared site-search log, not several

Council teams looking for hub or storage space are now logging it in one place — now covering a grocer's warehouse, a resident's garden storage, an unused car park and a Haringey industrial unit —

so different parts of the council stop independently approaching the same landlords.

BUILDING POLITICAL BACKING

A Sustain-style workshop, planned for Hackney's senior leaders

Mirroring the experiential "Future Food Dinner" format already run in Camden, to give councillors and senior leaders a shared, felt sense of what's possible — and build the political headroom this work needs to move.

ONGOING

This page, and the detailed working note, kept current

As the group's next monthly session (provisionally 12 October) and what follows produce real decisions, both this overview and the more detailed state-of-play note get updated — so anyone joining later doesn't start from zero either.

[↳ READ THE DETAILED WORKING NOTE](#)

Hackney Food Hub

An overview for everyone working on Hackney's food hub effort — part of the London Hubs & Markets Working Group, itself part of Dark Matter Labs' Food as Infrastructure portfolio.

This page is a working draft, not yet linked from the main portfolio homepage. Drawn from Hackney's food hub working sessions; names of individuals are omitted by default.

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